

BEYOND THE KINGDOM

Episode #0002

Air Date: Tuesday, January 4, 2005

Prod. #BTK-0002

Story Day: Tuesday, January 4, 2005, 12:14 AM - Wednesday,
January 5, 2005, 12:03 AM EST

Teleplay by the Beyond the Kingdom Writers' Room
Final Shooting Script

CAST OF CHARACTERS – EPISODE #0002

(ages as of Tuesday, January 4, 2005)

THE DONOHUES: SIMONE DONOHUE (94) · VICTOR DONOHUE (68) · JOAN DONOHUE (66)

THE OLSONS: CONGRESSWOMAN JASMINE DONOHUE OLSON (44) · DR. PETER OLSON (45) · MARTIN OLSON (23) · MALLORY OLSON (19)

THE BULLOCKS: ROBERT BULLOCK (45) · NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK (43) · CHIEF ELXA BULLOCK JACKSON (24) · DET. JEREMY JACKSON (24) · MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (22; turns 23 at midnight) · GRACE BULLOCK (20)

THE SMILLEYS: ODESSA SMILLEY (84) · LUCIUS SMILLEY (55) · LUKE SMILLEY (28) · ESTHER SMILLEY (22) · EMMA SMILLEY (2) · VICTORIA SMILLEY (2)

THE CIRCLE: AMOND BAKER (22) · ARIANNA CUMMINGS (22) · HARMONY DIVINE (22) · LYRIC SOLACE BAKER (2)

THE SEVEN (first full assembly): TOBIAS OKAFOR (24) · KEISHA "GHOST" LATTIMORE (25) · ROMAN GAINES (28) · DOLORES "MAMA DEE" WHITFIELD (53) · RASHAD "SAINT" MAYFIELD (23)

RECURRING: CELESTE VAUGHN (24) · CAMILLE RHODES (38) · SILAS MERRIWEATHER (57) · GLORIA BAKER (48) · DR. YVETTE CUMMINGS (51) · WINSTON FAIRLEY (62) · RUBY "NANA RUBY" TOLLIVER (66) · BRIELLE SUTTON (21) · BEATRIX "NANNY BEA" PENNINGTON (43) · THADDEUS CROWE (40)

SUPPORTING: GORDON ELLIS (36)

DAY PLAYERS: BERNICE WHITLOCK · OTIS (Merriweather lieutenant) · APD LAB TECH · DGH COURIER · THE SPEAKER OF THE HOUSE (O.S.) · FLORIST DELIVERY MAN

MENTIONED, NOT SEEN: Alvin Donohue (Miami) · the person on the other end of Martin's calls · Lamar Whitlock (the Piedmont Park victim, deceased)

FADE IN:

TEASER

1 INT. MARTIN OLSON'S LOFT — MIDTOWN — NIGHT

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 12:14 AM EST

Dark except for the blue pulse of police lights, still flickering in the trees of Piedmont Park beyond the windows.

MARTIN OLSON (23) sits in a leather chair facing the glass. The scotch from an hour ago is gone. He hasn't moved.

On the side table, a cordless phone RINGS. The caller ID reads: INTERNATIONAL.

He lets it ring twice, exactly twice, and answers.

MARTIN

(into phone)

It's six in the morning there.

You're up early.

(listening)

Of course. You never sleep.

(beat)

I watched it from my window.

(listening)

Yes.

(a small smile)

Exactly as you said it would.

He rises and walks to the glass. In the park, a coroner's van pulls slowly away.

MARTIN (CONT'D)

The Chief went herself. In dress blues. She promised the whole city Sovereign yesterday morning, and by dinner the city was promising her a body.

(listening)

No, sir. Nobody saw anything.

Nobody ever does.

(listening, his smile

fading)

I understand.

(beat)

I understand. Patience.

(beat)

Marc turns twenty-three tomorrow.

(listening)
Yes. I'll be there. I RSVP'd
"delighted."

He listens a long moment. Whatever he hears makes him close his eyes, the way a man does when he's praised by the only person whose praise he wants.

MARTIN (CONT'D)
(softly)
Thank you, sir. Good night.

He hangs up. He sets the phone down exactly parallel to the edge of the table.

CUT TO:

2 INT. THE BULLOCK PAVILION — MARC'S STUDY — DAWN
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 6:31 AM EST

A glass-walled study cantilevered over the river. Gray pre-dawn light. Marc hasn't been to bed. He's still in last night's tuxedo pants and a white undershirt, barefoot, surrounded by three laptops.

On speakerphone is the calm, flat voice of KEISHA "GHOST" LATTIMORE, the Syndicate's hacker.

KEISHA (V.O.)
(on speaker)
APD ran the prints at five-forty.
They got a hit.

MARC
Tell me.

KEISHA (V.O.)
Lamar Whitlock. Forty-three. Two priors for running numbers, one for receiving stolen property. Last known employer, according to his parole officer—
(beat)
Merriweather and Sons Funeral Home.

Marc goes very still.

MARC
Silas.

KEISHA (V.O.)

Lamar ran the numbers on the Southside for the Undertaker for fifteen years. Everybody on Ralph David Abernathy knew him. He brought his mama to church every Sunday.

MARC

So somebody walks into a park, shoots Silas Merriweather's man, and puts our coin in his hand.

KEISHA (V.O.)

Five months after the truce.

Marc looks out at the river, gray and cold.

MARC

Whoever did this doesn't just want the city to hate us, Ghost.
(beat)
They want Silas to.

KEISHA (V.O.)

What do you want me to do?

MARC

Everything. Crime scene photos. The M.E.'s report. Where Lamar ate, who he owed, who he loved.
(beat)
And Ghost, don't get caught inside APD. My sister's having a very long week.

KEISHA (V.O.)

Your sister's firewall was built in 1998. I could get caught on purpose and still get out.

She clicks off.

Marc stands alone in the dawn. He picks up the ONYX COIN from his desk and holds it up to the gray light.

MARC

(to the coin, quietly)
Happy almost-birthday to me.

SMASH CUT TO:

MAIN TITLES — "KINGDOM"

ACT ONE

3 INT. DONOHUE MANOR — THE MORNING ROOM — MORNING
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 7:32 AM EST

A sun-filled breakfast room overlooking the frozen garden. It's a smaller room than the grand dining room, and the more honest one. Coffee, eggs, and two newspapers.

VICTOR DONOHUE (68) reads the *Wall Street Journal*. Across the table, JOAN DONOHUE (66) reads the *Atlanta Sentinel*, folded to the front page.

INSERT — THE SENTINEL: "BODY IN PIEDMONT PARK CLUTCHED 'BLACKWATER' COIN" beside "SMILLEY TOWER RISES ON PEACHTREE"

JOAN
Your granddaughter made the front page twice.

VICTOR
(not looking up)
Once for the tower. Once for the body.

JOAN
Once for keeping a promise. Once for having it thrown back in her face.

Winston refills their coffee and withdraws to the doorway, a man who has learned to become furniture.

Joan folds the paper. She takes off her reading glasses. When Joan takes off her glasses, a verdict is coming.

JOAN (CONT'D)
Victor.

VICTOR
Joan.

JOAN
Did you call Jo Whitaker about Elxa?

Victor turns a page of the Journal. It takes him exactly one second too long.

VICTOR

I call Jo Whitaker about a great many things.

JOAN

That's not an answer.

VICTOR

It's the only kind the mayor's office ever gets from me.

JOAN

I'm not the mayor's office. I'm your wife.

(beat)

Elxa sat in the library last night and asked me if anybody picked up a phone for her. She said if somebody did, she didn't know what she'd do.

Victor sets down the paper at last.

VICTOR

Our granddaughter is the finest detective this city has produced in thirty years. The mayor had every reason to choose her.

JOAN

That's also not an answer.

VICTOR

(evenly)

Joan. In forty-five years, have I ever done anything to hurt one of our children?

JOAN

(beat)

Not on purpose.

That lands. Victor holds her eyes.

VICTOR

Then trust me on purpose.

He rises, kisses the top of her head, and takes his coat from Winston.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
I'll be at the Tower. The
Smilleys have lit their sign
again. Somebody has to glare at
it.

He goes. Joan sits alone, looking at the empty chair.

JOAN
(to Winston, without
turning)
He called her.

WINSTON
(neutral)
I couldn't say, ma'am.

JOAN
You couldn't say, or you won't?

WINSTON
(a long, loyal pause)
The coffee's fresh, ma'am.

Joan almost smiles. She puts her glasses back on and picks up the paper. But she doesn't read it.

CUT TO:

**4 INT. MERRIWEATHER & SONS FUNERAL HOME — WEST END — THE
FAMILY PARLOR — MORNING**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 8:16 AM EST

A 1920s brick funeral home on Ralph David Abernathy Boulevard. Inside, the parlor is heavy with dark velvet drapes, lilies, and a portrait of a stern founder. The organ music is piped in softly and never stops.

On a floral settee, a middle-aged woman in a church hat weeps into a handkerchief: BERNICE WHITLOCK, Lamar's widow.

Holding her hand is SILAS "THE UNDERTAKER" MERRIWEATHER (57). He looks forty-eight. He's elegant, with a silver beard, a black three-piece suit, and a gold watch chain. His voice is warm molasses, and his eyes are ice.

SILAS

—and we'll bring him home to you,
Bernice, soon as the county lets
him go. Mahogany casket. The good
silk lining. The choir from
Cascade. And every dime is on me.

BERNICE

(sobbing)

He was just going to see his
cousin. He was just walking.

SILAS

I know, baby.

BERNICE

Why would they— He didn't bother
nobody, Silas. He didn't bother—

SILAS

I know.

He helps her to her feet and walks her to the door. There,
a thick-necked lieutenant in a leather coat takes her
gently to a waiting car: OTIS (40s).

Silas closes the parlor door. The warmth drains out of his
face as if a tap had been turned.

He crosses to a side table where the *Sentinel* lies open.
He taps the headline with one finger. Blackwater.

OTIS (O.S.)

(re-entering)

Streets are hot, Silas. Our boys
want to go over to the West End
tonight and burn every one of
Saint's car washes to the slab.

SILAS

Our boys want a lot of things.

OTIS

We had a truce.

SILAS

We had a table in the back of
Dolores Whitfield's restaurant,
five months ago, where the young
man called Amond told me I could
keep my funeral homes and my
pride.

(beat)

A truce is a promise, Otis. A
coin in a dead man's hand is an
answer.

OTIS

So we go?

Silas walks to the window. Across the boulevard, two
blocks down, a hand-painted sign glows: DEE'S KITCHEN –
SOUL FOOD SINCE 1981.

SILAS

No. Not tonight.

(beat)

First, we send flowers.

OTIS

Flowers?

SILAS

This is a funeral home, Otis.

Flowers are what we do.

(turning)

Black lilies. A wreath. For
Dolores. And put a ribbon on it.

OTIS

What's the ribbon say?

Silas looks at the portrait of the founder, his father, on
the wall.

SILAS

"Sweet Auburn Truce. Rest in
Peace."

CUT TO:

**5 INT. CITY HALL EAST – APD HEADQUARTERS – CHIEF'S
OFFICE – MORNING**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 8:42 AM EST

A corner office that still has the previous chief's taste:
dark paneling, golf trophies, and a framed photo of Harold
Jackson with three mayors. Elxa hasn't had time to change
it. Stacks of files cover every surface.

CHIEF ELXA JACKSON (24) sits behind the desk in uniform,
reading a lab report. She has clearly slept at the office.

A KNOCK. The door opens before she answers.

Marc, now in a camel coat over a black turtleneck, fresh and bright as if he slept ten hours, carries a white paper bag spotted with powdered sugar and two coffees.

MARC

Chief. I come in peace, with beignets.

ELXA

(not looking up)

How did you get past the front desk?

MARC

I told Officer Ramirez it was your birthday.

(setting the bag on her files)

From Café Du Monde. I had them flown in. They're still warm, practically.

ELXA

You had beignets flown in from New Orleans.

MARC

Great-Grandma says the ones in Atlanta taste like "Methodist sadness."

Elxa finally looks up at him. Despite herself, she takes a beignet. Powdered sugar gets on her uniform. She glares at him, as though it's his fault.

MARC (CONT'D)

(sitting, picking up a beignet)

So. You look like you slept here.

ELXA

I did.

She eats in silence. He watches her. Then, casually:

MARC (CONT'D)

So. The park.

ELXA

(instantly)

No.

MARC
I didn't ask anything.

ELXA
You were about to.

MARC
I was about to say, I saw it on
Channel 8, and I was worried
about you. That's all.

ELXA
You saw it on Channel 8 because
somebody in this building called
Channel 8.

MARC
(sympathetic)
You've got a leak.

ELXA
I've got a colander.

MARC
Want me to find it? BSI does
counterintelligence. For free,
for you.

ELXA
(sharp)
No.

MARC
Elxa—

ELXA
I said no. I can't have the words
"Bullock" and "Blackwater" in the
same sentence this week, Marc.
Not even in a sentence that says
"Bullock helped." You know what
they'd write.

MARC
(gently)
Yeah. I know.

A beat. A real sister-and-brother moment. She looks tired
and very young.

ELXA
I stood up there yesterday and
promised this city I would find
him.

(beat)
And eleven hours later, he puts a
body in a park where people walk
their kids.

MARC
(carefully)
Maybe it wasn't him.

ELXA
It was his coin.

MARC
Coins can be copied.

Elxa looks at him sharply.

ELXA
Why would you say that?

MARC
(shrugging, mouth full
of beignet)
I run a security company.
Everything can be copied, Elx.
Passports. Paintings. Grandma's
pound cake. I've had a very nice
counterfeit Rolex since the tenth
grade.

The door BANGS open. Detective JEREMY JACKSON (24) hurries
in, a file in his hand, talking before he looks up.

JEREMY
Babe, we got the ID. Prints came
back. Lamar Whitlock,
forty-three, he ran numbers for
Silas Merriw-

He sees Marc. He stops dead.

Elxa closes her eyes.

MARC
(cheerfully)
Morning, Jeremy. Beignet?

JEREMY
(to Elxa, mortified)

I'm so sorry.

ELXA
(to Marc, cold)
Get out.

MARC
(rising, taking his
coffee)
I'm going. I'm going.
(at the door)
Silas Merriweather. Isn't he the
funeral guy? West End?

ELXA
MARC.

MARC
I'm GONE. Happy birthday to me.

He exits. The door closes.

Jeremy and Elxa stare at each other.

JEREMY
Your brother just heard an
unreleased victim ID from a
homicide detective in the Chief
of Police's office.

ELXA
I'm aware.

JEREMY
If that shows up in the paper—

ELXA
It won't be Marc.
(beat)
Marc doesn't talk to reporters.
He dates them.

She picks up another beignet and looks at the closed door
for a long moment.

ELXA (CONT'D)
(quietly)
"Coins can be copied."

JEREMY
What?

ELXA

Nothing.

(standing, all
business)

Merriweather. I want him in here
by noon, before his people decide
to handle this themselves.

JEREMY

Silas Merriweather doesn't come
to police stations.

ELXA

Then we go to him.

(grabbing her coat)

And Jeremy?

JEREMY

Yeah?

ELXA

(beat)

Don't call me "babe" in front of
civilians.

JEREMY

(sheepish)

Yes, Chief.

CUT TO:

**6 INT. SMILLEY TOWER — 71ST FLOOR — ESTHER'S OFFICE —
MORNING**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 9:21 AM EST

A white office, spare and razor-sharp: one orchid, one
painting (a small, perfect Matisse), and one wall of glass
facing Donohue Tower's gold crown.

ESTHER SMILLEY (22), in a charcoal sheath dress, stands at
a standing desk reading contracts, a phone at her ear.

THADDEUS CROWE (40) appears in the doorway holding a
cream-colored envelope as if it might explode.

CROWE

Miss Smilley.

ESTHER

What.

CROWE

A courier from Donohue Global Holdings just delivered this to the security desk downstairs. It's addressed to you by name.

He hands it over. Heavy cream stock. Gold edges. A gold CROWN embossed on the flap.

Esther turns it over in her hands. She opens it slowly.

INSERT – THE INVITATION: engraved script. "The Donohue Family requests the pleasure of your company at a celebration of the twenty-third birthday of MR. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK. Wednesday, the fifth of January, Two Thousand Five, at eight o'clock in the evening. Belle Rive, Twelve Sovereign Way, Belmont Crest. Black Tie." And, handwritten at the bottom in a spidery, elegant hand: "Welcome, neighbor. – S. T. D."

Esther stares at the initials.

ESTHER

S.T.D.

CROWE

(carefully)

Simone Toussaint Donohue, ma'am. I believe.

ESTHER

(a flicker of a smile
she can't stop)

I know who it is, Crowe.

Her door swings open without a knock. LUCIUS SMILLEY (55) enters on his silver cane. LUKE SMILLEY (28) trails him with a folder.

LUCIUS

Good morning, darling. Your brother has concerns about the Dubai numbers.

LUKE

I have concerns that nobody reads my Dubai numbers.

Lucius sees the envelope in Esther's hand and the gold crown.

LUCIUS

What is that?

ESTHER
An invitation.

LUCIUS
From?

ESTHER
(handing it to him)
The neighbors.

Lucius reads it. His face hardens. Luke reads over his shoulder.

LUKE
Oh, that's rich. The Donohue
heir's birthday party. They're
inviting us to watch them crown
him.

LUCIUS
(reading the
handwritten line)
"Welcome, neighbor."
(beat)
That old woman.

ESTHER
She's ninety-four, Daddy.

LUCIUS
She was ninety-four in 1970.
(handing it back)
Burn it.

ESTHER
It's a courtesy invitation. Their
bylaws require it. It's
automatic.

LUCIUS
Nothing Simone Donohue does is
automatic. She wants to see if
we'll come. And if we come, she
wants to see what we wear, who we
bring, how long we stay, and whom
we avoid.
(beat)
We don't go. The Smilleys do not
walk into Belle Rive to eat cake.
(beat)
Burn it, Esther.

ESTHER

Yes, Daddy.

Lucius nods, satisfied, and turns to go. As he does, his hand on the cane TREMBLES. It's fast and fine, like a plucked string. He steadies it by leaning harder.

Esther sees it this time. Her eyes narrow slightly. She says nothing.

They exit. Crowe waits.

CROWE

Shall I have it shredded?

Esther looks at the invitation. At the handwritten line. At the gold crown.

She opens her desk drawer and slides the invitation inside. She closes the drawer.

ESTHER

Thank you, Crowe. That's all.

Crowe leaves, and the corner of his mouth moves very slightly.

Esther turns to the window. Across Peachtree, the gold crown of Donohue Tower catches the morning sun.

ESTHER (CONT'D)

(to herself)

"Whom we avoid."

FADE OUT.

ACT TWO**7 INT. MERRIWEATHER & SONS FUNERAL HOME – WEST END – THE FAMILY PARLOR – DAY**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 11:08 AM EST

The same velvet parlor. The same soft organ music.

Elxa and Jeremy stand in the center of the room, in overcoats, not sitting. Silas sits comfortably in a wingback chair with a cup of tea, as if he had invited them.

Through an open door behind him is a back workroom. A FLORIST in an apron is working on an enormous funeral wreath of BLACK LILIES.

ELXA

Mr. Merriweather, I'm sorry for your loss.

SILAS

My loss?

ELXA

Lamar Whitlock worked for you for fifteen years.

SILAS

Lamar Whitlock drove a hearse for me for fifteen years, Chief. Part-time. He was a good driver. Never went over forty with a customer in the back.

JEREMY

His parole officer says he ran numbers on the Southside.

SILAS

(sipping tea)

His parole officer is misinformed. Lamar was a deacon.

JEREMY

A deacon with two priors.

SILAS

Jesus had a record too, Detective. Look how that turned out.

Jeremy's jaw tightens. Elxa stays calm.

ELXA

Mr. Merriweather. A man who worked for you was found holding a coin that belongs to the Blackwater Syndicate. Last summer, eleven of your properties burned in six weeks. Nobody was ever charged.

SILAS

Electrical fires. Old buildings.

ELXA

And in August, it stopped. Just stopped. Like somebody sat down and made a deal.

Silas sets his teacup down very gently on the saucer. Click.

SILAS

Chief. You're a Donohue.

ELXA

I'm a Jackson.

SILAS

You're a Donohue who married a Jackson.

(beat)

So let me tell you what your grandfather would tell you if he were standing here. Men like me don't make deals with ghosts. And men like me don't talk to police about ghosts. Not because we're afraid of the police.

(smiling)

Because we're afraid of the ghosts.

ELXA

Is that a threat?

SILAS

It's a condolence.

Behind him, the florist ties a long black satin RIBBON onto the wreath. Elxa's eyes go to it. She can't read the gold lettering from here.

ELXA
Who's the wreath for?

SILAS
(without turning)
A friend.

ELXA
Must be a close friend. That's
two hundred dollars of lilies.

SILAS
Four hundred. Black lilies are
out of season.
(standing, buttoning
his jacket)
If there's nothing else, I have a
widow to bury a husband for. Otis
will see you out.

Otis appears in the doorway like a wall.

Elxa holds Silas's eyes a moment longer. Then she hands
him her card.

ELXA
If your ghosts come calling, Mr.
Merriweather, call me before you
call anybody else.

SILAS
(taking the card,
pleasantly)
Chief. If my ghosts come calling,
nobody's going to have time to
call anybody.

EXT. MERRIWEATHER & SONS FUNERAL HOME – CONTINUOUS

Elxa and Jeremy walk to their unmarked car. It's cold, and
the West End is quiet and watchful.

JEREMY
That man just told us he's about
to start a war.

ELXA
No. That man just told us he
hasn't decided yet.
(opening the car door)
Put a car on this building.
Unmarked. Twenty-four hours.

JEREMY

Hughes says we don't have the overtime.

ELXA

Then Hughes can sit in it himself.

She gets in. Jeremy hesitates, looking back at the funeral home's window. Inside, the black wreath is being carried out the back door into a white van.

CUT TO:

8 INT. U.S. CAPITOL — HOUSE CHAMBER — DAY

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 12:04 PM EST

The opening day of the 109th Congress. The House chamber is packed with members and their families. Children in their Sunday best sit on laps. Cameras are in the galleries.

Among the members of the Georgia delegation, in a navy St. John suit and a small American-flag pin, stands CONGRESSWOMAN JASMINE DONOHUE OLSON (44).

In the gallery above, GORDON ELLIS (36), her Chief of Staff, watches with a BlackBerry in one hand and a camera in the other.

THE SPEAKER (O.S.)

The members-elect will rise and raise their right hands.

Four hundred and thirty-five people stand. Jasmine raises her right hand. She has done this nine times, and her eyes are still bright.

THE SPEAKER (O.S.) (CONT'D)

Do you solemnly swear that you
will support and defend the
Constitution of the United States
against all enemies, foreign and
domestic; that you will bear true
faith and allegiance to the same;
that you take this obligation
freely, without any mental
reservation or purpose of
evasion; and that you will well
and faithfully discharge the
duties of the office on which you
are about to enter, so help you
God?

JASMINE

(with the chamber)

I do.

APPLAUSE fills the chamber.

**INT. ATLANTA PRESBYTERIAN MEDICAL CENTER – SURGEONS'
LOUNGE – SAME TIME**

A small lounge with vending machines and a TV mounted in
the corner, tuned to C-SPAN.

DR. PETER OLSON (45), in surgical scrubs with his cap
still on, stands in front of the TV holding a cup of
vending-machine coffee. When he sees Jasmine's hand in the
air on the screen, he raises his cup to the TV.

PETER

(softly)

Ten.

DR. YVETTE CUMMINGS (51), who looks thirty-nine, enters in
a white coat with a cardiology badge and a stethoscope
around her neck. She's elegant and brisk, and she carries
a lunch bag.

YVETTE

Is that her?

PETER

Third row, in navy.

YVETTE

(peering)

Of course she's in navy. That
woman has never made a wrong

fashion choice in her life.

PETER

Gordon picked it.

YVETTE

Then Gordon has never made a
wrong fashion choice.

She sits, unwrapping a sandwich. It's turkey on wheat, cut diagonally.

PETER

How's our new District Attorney?

Yvette's face shifts. She puts the sandwich down.

YVETTE

She called me at one o'clock this
morning.

PETER

Crying about the park?

YVETTE

She wouldn't say. She just said
she needed to hear my voice.

(beat)

Peter, Arianna doesn't cry. She
didn't cry when she broke her arm
at nine. She didn't cry at her
grandmother's funeral. She hasn't
cried in front of me since—

She stops.

PETER

Since?

YVETTE

(slowly)

Since New Year's. Three years
ago. She came home from a party
and went straight to her room,
and she wouldn't come out for two
days. She said it was the flu.

(beat)

I'm a doctor. It wasn't the flu.

Peter watches her. He knows something about keeping
secrets. He says nothing.

On the TV, the chamber applauds. Jasmine hugs a colleague.

YVETTE (CONT'D)
(forcing brightness)
Anyway. She packed her own lunch
today. First time since she was
twelve.

PETER
That's progress.

YVETTE
(looking at her
sandwich)
Is it?

CUT TO:

9 INT. U.S. CAPITOL — STATUARY HALL — DAY
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 12:41 PM EST

Marble statues and echoing footsteps. Members pose for
photos with their families.

Jasmine walks fast with Gordon at her side, both on cell
phones.

JASMINE
(into her phone,
stopping)
Hi, baby. It's Mama.
(listening)
Martin? You there?

INTERCUT WITH:

**INT. DONOHUE TOWER — MARTIN'S OFFICE — 86TH FLOOR —
CONTINUOUS**

A handsome corner office two floors below Victor's. Every
surface is clear. Martin sits behind his desk with the
phone to his ear, reviewing a thick stack of property
DEEDS.

MARTIN
I'm here, Mother.
Congratulations. I watched it.

JASMINE
You did?

MARTIN

On the computer. The feed was delayed. You raised the wrong hand at first. Then you corrected.

JASMINE

(laughing)

I did NOT.

MARTIN

(the faintest smile)

You didn't. I just wanted to hear you laugh.

Jasmine's face softens in the marble hall.

JASMINE

I'm proud of you, Martin. You know that?

MARTIN

(beat)

I know, Mother.

JASMINE

Are you going to your cousin's party tomorrow?

MARTIN

Of course.

JASMINE

Be nice.

MARTIN

(looking down at the deeds, all bearing the name ALEXANDER J. DONOHUE)

I'm always nice.

END INTERCUT.

Jasmine hangs up, beaming. Gordon waits.

GORDON

Everything okay?

JASMINE

Everything's perfect. My son called me. Well, I called him. But he answered.

GORDON

(dry)

That's a Donohue family win.

JASMINE

(walking again)

Don't be smart, Gordon. Tell the *Journal-Constitution* they get ten minutes.

CUT TO:

10 INT. FULTON COUNTY COURTHOUSE – DISTRICT ATTORNEY'S OFFICE – DAY

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 1:07 PM EST

Arianna's office, a little more hers today: a framed Emory Law diploma on the wall and a photo of her parents. Tate's portrait is gone. There's a pale rectangle on the wall where it hung.

DISTRICT ATTORNEY ARIANNA CUMMINGS (22) sits across a small conference table from Elxa. Between them lie crime-scene photos, face down.

ARIANNA

—so the moment you have a suspect, I want to know. Not the moment you have an arrest. The moment you have a name.

ELXA

You'll have it.

ARIANNA

And I want this office on every search warrant. If this ends up in front of a jury, I'm not losing it on a technicality because somebody at APD forgot to dot an "i."

ELXA

Nobody forgets to dot an "i" in my department.

ARIANNA

Somebody in your department called Channel 8.

Elxa's jaw tightens. Arianna softens a little.

ARIANNA (CONT'D)

I'm sorry. That was a cheap shot.

ELXA

It was an accurate shot.

(beat)

It's Hughes. I can't prove it yet, but it's Hughes.

ARIANNA

Warren Hughes smiled through your whole press conference.

ELXA

You noticed that?

ARIANNA

Everybody noticed that.

They're peers: two twenty-something women in impossible jobs, being watched by a whole city waiting for them to fail.

Elxa turns over one of the photos: a close-up of the ONYX COIN in the dead man's palm.

ELXA

Have you ever seen one of these up close?

Arianna looks at the photo. Something moves behind her eyes and is gone.

ARIANNA

Only in the papers.

ELXA

The one from the Harlow case in 2000 is in our evidence room. I'm having the lab compare them tonight.

ARIANNA

Why?

ELXA

(slowly)

Because my brother came to my office this morning with beignets from New Orleans and said, "Coins can be copied."

Arianna doesn't blink.

ARIANNA

Marc says a lot of things.

ELXA

Marc never brings beignets.

ARIANNA

It's his birthday week. He's generous on his birthday. Last year he bought the whole Morehouse glee club new robes.

(beat)

You're not seriously—

ELXA

No.

(too quickly)

No. I'm tired, and I'm seeing things.

(beat)

But you'd tell me. Wouldn't you? If Marc were in trouble?

A long beat. Arianna holds her gaze. She is very good at this.

ARIANNA

Elxa. Marc is always in trouble. It's his hobby. He'd be bored to death otherwise.

(she turns the photo back over)

But not this kind.

Elxa nods slowly. She gathers the photos.

ELXA

The moment I have a name.

ARIANNA

The moment you have a name.

Elxa leaves. The door closes.

Arianna sits alone. Her hands are flat on the table, completely steady.

Then she reaches for her office phone. She dials four digits and stops. She hangs up.

She takes out her silver RAZR instead, opens it, and types a text message.

INSERT – TEXT TO "M": "Your sister thinks coins can be copied. Where did she get THAT idea?"

She sends it. Almost immediately, the phone buzzes.

INSERT – TEXT FROM "M": "No idea. Must be the beignets. :)"

Arianna closes the phone and looks at the ceiling.

ARIANNA
(under her breath)
I'm going to kill him.

FADE OUT.

ACT THREE

11 INT. PHIPPS PLAZA — PARKING DECK — LEVEL 3 — DAY
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 1:44 PM EST

Concrete, fluorescent light, and the echo of car alarms. It's the handoff spot: neutral ground, halfway between Harmony's townhouse and Amond's penthouse, with the lawyers' approval.

A dented silver Honda Civic is parked crookedly across two spaces. HARMONY DIVINE (22) stands at its open back door, unbuckling a car seat. Inside, LYRIC SOLACE BAKER (2) sings to her giraffe.

The black Range Rover pulls into the space beside it with precision. AMOND BAKER (22) gets out in a black peacoat, with a Tiffany-blue gift bag in one hand.

The rules of the handoff are clear to both of them: no talking. Just the child, the bag, and ten minutes. They've done this a hundred times.

Amond holds out his arms.

Harmony doesn't hand him Lyric. She hands him the entire CAR SEAT, with the baby in it, and shoves it into his arms so hard he staggers.

AMOND

Whoa—

HARMONY

Your MOTHER, Amond?

AMOND

Harmony—

HARMONY

Your MOTHER?!

AMOND

I didn't know!

LYRIC

(from the car seat,
delighted)
Mommy's yelling!

HARMONY

(to Lyric, instantly
sweet)

Mommy's not yelling, baby,
Mommy's using her outside voice.

(to Amond, full volume)

I got SERVED, Amond. At WORK. In
front of my BROKER. A process
server walked into a real estate
office in Buckhead and said
"Harmony Divine?" in front of a
client, and I thought, "Oh God,
it's the IRS," and it was WORSE.
It was GLORIA BAKER.

AMOND

I found out yesterday. After I
saw you. I swear to God.

HARMONY

You expect me to believe your
mother filed a legal petition for
visitation with my daughter and
you didn't know?

AMOND

Our daughter.

HARMONY

Oh, NOW she's "our" daughter!

AMOND

She's always been our daughter!

HARMONY

Then where were you when she had
croup in October?

AMOND

I paid for the specialist!

HARMONY

I didn't need a check, Amond! I
needed somebody to hold the
humidifier while I held her!

That hits. Amond sets the car seat down very carefully on
the hood of the Range Rover. Lyric looks from one parent
to the other, fascinated.

AMOND

(quieter)

You never called me.

HARMONY

You never gave me a reason to
think you'd pick up.

AMOND

I ALWAYS pick up for her.

HARMONY

For HER. Through your LAWYER.
With a CHECK. You've never once
called me and asked how I was
doing. Not once in three years.

Silence. The echo of a car alarm somewhere.

AMOND

How are you doing?

HARMONY

(stunned, then furious)
Don't you DARE do that now—

AMOND

I'm asking.

HARMONY

In a PARKING DECK?

AMOND

You picked the parking deck!

HARMONY

Your LAWYER picked the parking
deck!

LYRIC

(clapping)
Parking deck!

Both parents stop and look at their daughter. She is
beaming at them, having the time of her life.

A long beat. Harmony's anger cracks and something tired
and sad shows through.

HARMONY

(quiet)
She's the only thing I have
that's all the way mine, Amond.
Everything else, I'm still paying
off. My car. My school loans. My
brother's flyers.
(beat)

And your mother wants Sundays.

AMOND
I'll talk to her.

HARMONY
Talk to her today.

AMOND
Today.

He picks up the car seat again, gently this time. Lyric reaches for his face.

LYRIC
Daddy, Mommy's outside voice is
LOUD.

AMOND
(to Lyric, not taking
his eyes off Harmony)
I know, Lyric-bird. It's the
loudest voice in Georgia.

HARMONY
(despite herself, the
smallest twitch of a
smile)
Six o'clock. Here. Not
six-oh-five.

AMOND
Six o'clock.

She climbs into her Honda. It takes three tries to start.
She drives off.

Amond stands in the parking deck holding his daughter in
her car seat and a Tiffany bag he never gave anyone.

LYRIC
What's in the bag?

AMOND
(looking at it)
It was for your mommy. Happy New
Year.

LYRIC
She didn't take it.

AMOND
(beat)

No, baby. She didn't.

CUT TO:

**12 INT. THE BAKER HOME – 214 MAGNOLIA TERRACE – KITCHEN
– DAY**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 2:22 PM EST

A lovely, lived-in family kitchen inside Belmont Crest's gates: modest by Summit standards and warm by any standard. Kiara's report cards are on the fridge. There's a Bible on the counter and a pot of greens on the stove.

GLORIA BAKER (48), who looks thirty-eight, is still in her principal's suit and cardigan, grading papers at the kitchen table.

The back door opens. Amond walks in carrying Lyric on his hip.

GLORIA
(looking up, stunned,
then melting)
Oh. Oh, Lord.

LYRIC
Hi, Grandma!

GLORIA
(standing so fast her
chair falls over)
Hi, baby! Hi, my baby!

She takes Lyric from Amond and holds her close, rocking her. Her eyes close. For a moment she's somewhere else entirely.

Amond watches his mother. His anger has nowhere to go.

AMOND
You filed a petition, Mama.

GLORIA
(not letting go of
Lyric)
I did.

AMOND
Without telling me.

GLORIA
You'd have told me not to.

AMOND

Of COURSE I'd have told you not
to! She got served at work! In
front of her broker!

GLORIA

(to Lyric, sweetly)

Do you want some juice, pumpkin?

LYRIC

Apple!

GLORIA

Apple.

(pouring juice, to
Amond, not sweetly)

Eleven times.

AMOND

What?

GLORIA

I have held my granddaughter
eleven times in two years and
eight months, Amond. I counted.
Christmas at the Pavilion because
Marc invited everybody. Her first
birthday for forty minutes. The
christening. The hospital, once,
when she was born, and Harmony's
mother looked at me like I'd come
to steal something.

(beat, her voice
breaking a little)

I'm a principal. I have eleven
hundred children I see every day.
And I've seen my own grandbaby
eleven times.

Amond has no answer.

GLORIA (CONT'D)

Your father works until nine.
Your sister is fifteen and thinks
I'm the enemy. I come home to
this kitchen and it's quiet,
baby. It's so quiet.

She kisses Lyric's curls.

GLORIA (CONT'D)

I didn't file it to hurt that girl. I filed it because I didn't know how else to knock.

AMOND

(softly)

You could've knocked on MY door, Mama.

GLORIA

(meeting his eyes)

I've been knocking on your door since you were eighteen, son. You and Marc and whatever you two do all night.

That lands. Amond looks away.

LYRIC

(from her grandmother's arms, pointing at the stove)

Greens!

GLORIA

(laughing through tears)

She likes greens. Did you know that? She likes greens.

AMOND

(beat)

No. I didn't know that.

A silence. Gloria sets Lyric in a chair with her juice and turns to her son.

GLORIA

I'll withdraw it.

AMOND

Mama—

GLORIA

If Harmony lets me have one Sunday a month. Just one. Church, and dinner, and I bring her back by six.

(beat)

You ask her. Not your lawyer. You.

Amond looks at his daughter, who is drinking apple juice with enormous concentration.

AMOND
(beat)
Okay.

Gloria hugs her son hard. Over her shoulder, Amond closes his eyes.

CUT TO:

13 INT. BSI TOWER – MARC'S OFFICE – 58TH FLOOR – DAY
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 3:04 PM EST

The wall of monitors. Sri Lanka, Jakarta, Houston, Savannah.

Marc sits on the edge of his desk. Across from him, in a perfectly tailored gray suit with a laptop open on his knees, is TOBIAS OKAFOR (24). Nigerian-American, bespectacled, and precise, he has the air of a man who counts everything, including his own heartbeats.

BRIELLE SUTTON (21) is on a phone in the corner, whispering furiously about ice sculptures.

TOBIAS
Tsunami relief to date: forty-one million, three hundred thousand dollars. We're over budget by exactly the amount you told Roman not to care about.

MARC
Good.

Tobias types without comment. Then, not looking up, in exactly the same tone:

TOBIAS
Also, the other ledger.

Brielle is still on her call across the room. Marc's eyes flick to her, then back.

MARC
(casually)
Mm-hm?

TOBIAS
(still typing, still
neutral)

The gentleman from the park. He
had a bank account at a credit
union on Cascade Road. Deposits
every Friday, very regular. Then,
on December tenth, one deposit
that was not regular. Twenty
thousand dollars. Cash.

MARC
From?

TOBIAS
Unknown. Yet.

MARC
December tenth.

TOBIAS
The day after Smilley
International announced its move
to Atlanta. Not that it's
related.

MARC
(beat)
Not that it's related.

Brielle hangs up and swings over, clipboard first.

BRIELLE
Okay. The ice sculpture guy can
do a swan or a crown. Not both.

MARC
Why not both?

BRIELLE
Because a crowned swan looks, and
I'm quoting him, "like a duck
that won the lottery."

MARC
(delighted)
I WANT the duck that won the
lottery.

BRIELLE
(writing)
One lottery duck.
(new page)

Also, the Belmont Crest gate log came in from BSI Communities. You asked me to flag anything unusual.

She hands him a printout. He scans it. His eyebrows rise.

INSERT — THE LOG: "CROWN GATE — 01/03/05 — 08:31:07 — BLACK MAYBACH 62, GA TAG: SMILLEY 1 — IDLED 58 SECONDS — NO ENTRY REQUESTED — DEPARTED EASTBOUND."

MARC
Esther Smilley stopped at my gate.

BRIELLE
For fifty-eight seconds. CrestWatch already posted about it last night.

MARC
Who IS CrestWatch?

BRIELLE
Nobody knows. It's the biggest mystery in Buckhead.

TOBIAS
(not looking up)
Second biggest.

Marc shoots him a look. Tobias keeps typing.

MARC
(reading the log again)
Fifty-eight seconds. What do you do at somebody's gate for fifty-eight seconds?

BRIELLE
Look.

MARC
Look at what?

BRIELLE
(shrugging)
Whatever you're scared of. Or whatever you want. It's usually the same thing.

Marc looks up at her.

MARC

Brielle, when did you get wise?

BRIELLE

I've been wise since you hired me. You just don't listen.

(heading out)

Lottery duck. Got it.

She's gone. Marc looks at the log one more time. He folds it and puts it in his breast pocket.

TOBIAS

(closing his laptop)

Roman lands at four-fifty.

MARC

Tell Saint to pick him up.

TOBIAS

In the Cutlass?

MARC

Roman hates the Cutlass.

TOBIAS

I know.

MARC

(grinning)

Then definitely the Cutlass.

CUT TO:

14 EXT. DEKALB-PEACHTREE AIRPORT – PRIVATE TARMAC – DAY
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 4:53 PM EST

The sun is low and gold. A black BSI Gulfstream with no markings except a small crown-and-wave on the tail rolls to a stop.

On the tarmac, leaning against a gleaming candy-apple-red 1972 OLDSMOBILE CUTLASS SUPREME with gold rims, is RASHAD "SAINT" MAYFIELD (23). He's lanky and charming, with a gold chain, a crisp white T-shirt under a leather jacket, and an easy grin that has talked him out of forty arrests.

The jet stairs lower. ROMAN GAINES (28) descends, carrying one small duffel. He has flown twenty-two hours from Colombo with one fuel stop. He looks exactly the same as when he left: calm, enormous, and unreadable.

He sees the Cutlass. He stops.

ROMAN

No.

SAINT

Welcome home, big man!

ROMAN

I'm not getting in that.

SAINT

It's a classic!

ROMAN

It's a fire hazard with rims.

SAINT

(opening the passenger
door, bowing)

Marc said.

Roman stares at the car for a long moment. He sighs, the sigh of a man who has survived two wars and a tsunami and will now survive this. He folds himself into the passenger seat. His knees hit the dashboard.

**INT./EXT. THE CUTLASS – MOVING – PEACHTREE INDUSTRIAL
BOULEVARD – CONTINUOUS**

Saint drives with one wrist on the wheel. Roman sits with his knees at his chest.

SAINT

How was Sri Lanka?

ROMAN

(beat)

The water came in eight feet over
the top of the seawall. We found
a school bus a mile inland.
Upside down in a paddy.

(beat)

Four hundred and twelve kids in
the camp. They all got shoes.

Saint looks at him. The grin fades.

SAINT

Marc's shoes?

ROMAN

Marc's shoes.

A beat of respect. Then:

ROMAN (CONT'D)

Talk to me.

SAINT

(the easy tone gone)
Streets are bad. Merriweather's
boys are saying it was us.
They're saying we broke the
truce. My guys on the West End
got told to watch their car
washes tonight.

ROMAN

Did we break it?

SAINT

Man, you know we didn't.

ROMAN

Then who did?

SAINT

That's why you're here. The Table
sits tonight. Eleven. All seven.

(beat, the grin
creeping back)

You want wings first? You look
hungry. It's your whole face.

ROMAN

(closing his eyes)

Drive.

FADE OUT.

ACT FOUR**15 INT. DEE'S KITCHEN — WEST END — DUSK**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 5:36 PM EST

A legendary soul-food restaurant on Ralph David Abernathy Boulevard. Twelve red vinyl booths. A counter with swivel stools. A wall covered in framed photos of every famous person who's eaten here, from civil rights leaders to rappers, all signed. The air smells like fried chicken, candied yams, and heaven.

The dinner rush is starting. WAITRESSES in red aprons hustle. A radio on the counter plays gospel.

Behind the counter, in a crisp white apron with reading glasses on a beaded chain, stands DOLORES "MAMA DEE" WHITFIELD (53). She looks forty-five, round and regal, and she stirs a pot of greens like she's conducting an orchestra. She moves like the queen of the West End, because she is.

MAMA DEE

(to a young WAITRESS)

Tanisha, table four wants more cornbread. Table four ALWAYS wants more cornbread. Bring it before they ask, baby. That's hospitality.

The bell over the door JINGLES. The whole restaurant goes quiet.

A DELIVERY MAN in a white uniform carries in an enormous funeral WREATH of BLACK LILIES on a wire easel. A long black satin ribbon hangs from it, lettered in gold.

He sets it in the middle of the restaurant floor, in front of the counter.

DELIVERY MAN

Delivery for Mrs. Dolores Whitfield.

Every customer is staring. A child in a booth whispers to his mother. The gospel keeps playing.

Mama Dee comes around the counter slowly. She takes off her reading glasses and lets them fall on their chain. She lifts the ribbon.

INSERT — THE RIBBON, in gold on black satin: "SWEET AUBURN TRUCE — REST IN PEACE."

She looks at it for a long moment.

Then she smooths the ribbon flat, calmly and gently, the way she'd straighten a child's collar.

MAMA DEE
(to the delivery man)
Who sent it, baby?

DELIVERY MAN
The card says "a friend," ma'am.

MAMA DEE
Mm-hm.
(she reaches into her
apron, pulls out a
twenty, and presses it
into his hand)
You tell your "friend" the lilies
are beautiful. Black lilies are
out of season. Tell him Dolores
Whitfield noticed he paid extra.

The delivery man leaves as fast as he can.

The restaurant is silent. Mama Dee turns to her customers and smiles like sunshine.

MAMA DEE (CONT'D)
Y'all go on and eat. It's just
flowers. Tanisha, move this
pretty thing to the back so
nobody gets sad over their peach
cobbler.

The chatter slowly resumes.

Mama Dee walks behind the counter, through the swinging kitchen doors, and past the cooks into a tiny back office. She closes the door behind her.

INT. DEE'S KITCHEN — BACK OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

A cramped office: invoices on a spike, a church calendar, a framed photo of a smiling teenage boy in a graduation cap, and a hot plate.

Mama Dee picks up an old rotary phone and dials from memory.

MAMA DEE
(into phone)
Baby. It's Mama Dee.
(listening)
I know you're busy. Everybody's
busy.
(beat)
Tell Sovereign the Undertaker
just sent me flowers.

She listens. Her eyes go to the photo of the boy in the graduation cap.

MAMA DEE (CONT'D)
No. Nobody's hurt. Not yet.
(beat)
Eleven o'clock. I'll bring a pie.

She hangs up. She stands there a moment, her hand still on the phone.

Then she picks up the photograph of the boy and wipes the glass with her apron.

MAMA DEE (CONT'D)
(to the photo, softly)
Not again, sugar. Not on my
street. Not again.

CUT TO:

16 INT. BONES RESTAURANT – BUCKHEAD – A CORNER BOOTH – NIGHT

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 6:21 PM EST

Buckhead's most famous steakhouse: dark wood, white tablecloths, and caricatures of power brokers on the walls. The power-dinner crowd is in suits.

In a corner booth, Marc and CELESTE VAUGHN (24) sit close, sharing a wedge salad. She's in a sleek black dress, on her dinner break, with her RAZR and pager both on the table. She is electric.

CELESTE
—and my news director said, and I
quote, "Vaughn, that's the best
eleven o'clock open this
station's had since the
Olympics."

MARC
(laughing)
You're a menace.

CELESTE
I'm a professional.
(stealing his crouton)
We led every station in the
market last night. By ten points.
Ten, Marc. Do you know what that
means?

MARC
You get a bigger desk?

CELESTE
It means New York is watching.
One more story like that and I'm
anchoring the six o'clock by
spring.

She's glowing. Marc watches her with real fondness and
something more complicated.

MARC
So how'd you get it?

CELESTE
Get what?

MARC
The coin. Nobody else had the
coin. Channel 2 didn't have it.
Channel 5 didn't have it. You had
it, live, in forty-five minutes.

CELESTE
(coy)
A reporter never reveals her
sources.

MARC
I'm not asking for a name.

CELESTE
Good, because you're not getting
one.
(leaning in, lowering
her voice, unable to
resist)
Let's just say somebody very high
up at APD doesn't like his new
boss very much.

Marc keeps smiling. Something behind his eyes files it away.

MARC

"His."

CELESTE

(catching herself)

Or hers. I didn't say anything.

(pointing her fork at
him)

And you can't tell your sister.

MARC

(raising his hands)

My sister thinks I'm a doughnut
with legs. She doesn't take my
calls.

CELESTE

(sipping her wine,
dreamily)

This Sovereign story is going to
make my career, Marc. Everybody
in this city wants to know who he
is. The first person who finds
out wins everything.

MARC

(pleasantly)

What if he's somebody boring?

CELESTE

Nobody who does what he does is
boring.

MARC

Maybe he's an accountant. With a
mustache. Named Gary.

CELESTE

(laughing)

Gary.

MARC

Gary Sovereign. Drives a Camry.
Coaches Little League. Allergic
to shellfish.

CELESTE

Stop it.

MARC
(grinning)
I'd love to meet him. Wouldn't
you?

CELESTE
(with total sincerity)
I'd give anything.

A beat. He looks at her. She has no idea how close she's
sitting to her story.

Her pager BUZZES. She reads it and grabs her purse.

CELESTE (CONT'D)
Damn. APD's holding a briefing at
seven-fifteen. I have to go.

MARC
Go. Win.

She kisses him, quick and hungry, and slides out of the
booth.

CELESTE
Your birthday tomorrow. I'm
coming. I'm wearing red. Don't
wear anything that clashes.

MARC
I'll wear red too.

CELESTE
Do NOT wear red.

She's gone in a swirl of black dress and ambition.

Marc sits alone in the booth. The smile fades slowly from
his face.

He takes out his RAZR and types.

INSERT – TEXT TO "GHOST": "Warren Hughes. Phone records.
Everything since Dec 20."

He sends it. He closes the phone. He finishes her wine.

CUT TO:

**17 INT. BULLOCK & ASSOCIATES, LLP – ROBERT'S OFFICE –
40TH FLOOR – NIGHT**

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 7:14 PM EST

A corner office in a Peachtree Center tower. Leather, law books, and a wall of framed newspaper headlines celebrating verdicts: "NOT GUILTY." "ACQUITTED." "JURY SIDES WITH BULLOCK." A bar cart. The city glitters below.

ROBERT BULLOCK (45) sits on the edge of his desk with his tie loosened, reading a file.

Leaning in the doorway with two glasses of bourbon is CAMILLE RHODES (38), who looks twenty-eight. She's the firm's senior partner: sharp, gorgeous, and patient in a way that makes other lawyers nervous. She wears a fitted gray suit and her hair up. When she enters, the faint scent of her perfume enters with her.

CAMILLE

You're still here.

ROBERT

So are you.

CAMILLE

I'm always here. You're only here
when you don't want to be
somewhere else.

She hands him a glass. They clink without a word.

ROBERT

(sniffing the air)
New perfume.

CAMILLE

(sitting on the arm of
the leather sofa)
It's called Smile. Vivienne
Smilley's line. Neiman's was
giving out samples. It seemed
patriotic, in a city that's
suddenly got two royal families.

ROBERT

(beat)
Don't wear it to the house.

CAMILLE

(amused)
I've never been to your house,
Robert.

ROBERT

Don't wear it near my wife, then.

CAMILLE

Your wife would have to stand near me first. Natasha Bullock hasn't looked directly at me since the Christmas party in 2001.

ROBERT

She didn't know then.

CAMILLE

(sipping)

Women always know, Robert. We just decide how long to pretend we don't.

That sits between them. Robert sets his glass down.

ROBERT

What do you want, Camille?

CAMILLE

Tonight? Nothing. I came to tell you about a phone call.

(beat)

Silas Merriweather's office called this afternoon. His man Otis. They wanted to know one thing.

ROBERT

Which is?

CAMILLE

Whether Bullock and Associates represents the Blackwater Syndicate.

Robert laughs. It's short and genuine.

ROBERT

What'd you tell him?

CAMILLE

That this firm represents anybody who can afford us, and we don't discuss our clients with morticians.

ROBERT
Good answer.

CAMILLE
(watching him)
Do we?

ROBERT
Do we what?

CAMILLE
Represent them.

Robert picks his glass back up. He takes a slow sip.

ROBERT
We represent a lot of people who
pay in cash, Camille. Some of
them pay very well, very
promptly, through very nice
corporations. I don't ask what
they do at night.
(beat)
Neither should you.

CAMILLE
(standing, setting her
glass down)
I'm not asking what they do at
night.

She crosses to him and straightens his tie. It's intimate
and practiced.

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
I'm asking what YOU do at night.

ROBERT
(quiet)
Tonight I go home to my wife and
eat Ruby's smothered chicken and
talk about my son's birthday
party.

CAMILLE
(her hands still on his
tie)
And tomorrow?

He looks at her for a long moment. Then he kisses her.
It's slow, and it's clearly not the first time.

She pulls back first. She always does.

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
(picking up her glass,
heading for the door)
Go home, Robert. Your chicken's
getting cold.

She leaves. Robert stands alone in his office full of
framed acquittals.

He sniffs his collar. Smile.

ROBERT
(to himself)
Damn it.

CUT TO:

18 INT. RAVENHURST – THE NURSERY – NIGHT
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 7:49 PM EST

A fairy-tale nursery: twin white canopy beds, a
hand-painted mural of the Chicago skyline, a rocking
horse, and a small mountain of stuffed animals.

Emma is in bed, perfectly tucked in, with her picture
book. Victoria is standing on her mattress, jumping.

Esther sits between the beds in a silk robe. NANNY BEA
(43) folds tiny clothes in the corner.

ESTHER
Victoria Simone. Bottom on the
bed.

VICTORIA
(jumping)
I'm a FROG!

ESTHER
Frogs sleep too.

VICTORIA
Frogs sleep in the WATER.

EMMA
(not looking up from
her book)
Frogs are amphibians. They sleep
in water or on land.

Esther and Bea exchange a look. Two years and seven months
old.

ESTHER
(to Emma)
Where did you learn "amphibians"?

EMMA
Nanny Bea's television.

BEA
(mildly)
The Discovery Channel. It was
that or Barney, madam. I have
limits.

Victoria collapses on her bed, finally, breathless. She
stares at the ceiling.

VICTORIA
Mommy.

ESTHER
Yes, Dividend.

VICTORIA
Where's the funny man?

Esther's hand stops on the blanket. Bea stops folding.

ESTHER
What funny man, baby?

VICTORIA
The funny man with the crown. On
the TV.

EMMA
(helpfully, turning a
page)
He lives in the castle across the
trees. Harmony said.

Esther looks at Emma. Emma looks back at her with Marc's
solemn, patient eyes, though nobody in this room could say
so.

ESTHER
(carefully)
He's just a man on television,
girls. Like the weatherman.

VICTORIA
I like him.

ESTHER
(tucking her in, too
firmly)
Go to sleep.

VICTORIA
Can he come to our birthday?

ESTHER
Your birthday isn't until May.

VICTORIA
Can he come in MAY?

ESTHER
(standing)
Good night, girls.

She kisses them both and switches off the lamp. A
nightlight glows: a little silver crescent moon.

She walks out quickly. Bea watches her go. Then she looks
at the two little girls, one already asleep, one staring
at the ceiling and smiling.

CUT TO:

INT. RAVENHURST – THE LIBRARY – CONTINUOUS
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 7:58 PM EST

The fire crackles. Lucius stands at the mantel with a
brandy. ODESSA SMILLEY (84) reclines on a velvet chaise in
a caftan, with a cigarette holder she doesn't actually use
anymore, for the drama.

Esther enters and goes straight to the bar.

ODESSA
The frog's asleep?

ESTHER
The frog is plotting.

ODESSA
Good. A girl should always be
plotting.

LUCIUS
(to Esther)
Did you burn it?

Esther pours herself a glass of wine. She takes a long sip before she answers.

ESTHER
I'm thinking about going.

LUCIUS
(sharply)
You are not.

ODESSA
(delighted)
Oh, she is.

LUCIUS
Mother.

ESTHER
It's reconnaissance, Daddy. Every family that matters in Atlanta will be in that house tomorrow night. Senators. The mayor. Half the Fortune 500. We just moved our entire company here. Do you want me to meet them at their parties, or at ours, where they'll feel like they're doing us a favor?

Lucius opens his mouth, then closes it. She's right, and he hates it.

LUCIUS
And the Donohues?

ESTHER
I'll say hello to Victor. I'll compliment Natasha's dress. I'll let Simone look at me for as long as she likes.

ODESSA
She'll look at you like you're a stain on her tablecloth.

ESTHER
Then I'll be the most beautiful stain she's ever seen.

Odessa CACKLES and claps her hands.

ODESSA
Wear red.

ESTHER

Red?

ODESSA

Red. Every woman in that house will be in black because it's a Donohue party and they're all in mourning for their taste. Wear red, and when you walk in, every head turns.

LUCIUS

She's not walking in anywhere.

ESTHER

(sweetly, kissing her
father's cheek)

I'll think about it, Daddy.

Esther takes her wine and walks to the window. Across the dark ravine, the lights of the Summit burn on the bluff. One house is lit brighter than the others, a Mediterranean palazzo glowing gold: Belle Rive, being prepared for a party.

She watches it.

ODESSA (CONT'D)

(watching her
granddaughter)

And the birthday boy?

ESTHER

(not turning)

What about him?

ODESSA

Will you say hello to HIM?

A long pause.

ESTHER

(evenly)

I'll avoid him.

Odessa and Lucius exchange a look. Lucius sees only defiance. Odessa sees something else, and she smiles to herself and sips her brandy.

FADE OUT.

ACT FIVE

19 INT. DONOHUE TOWER — NATASHA'S OFFICE — 87TH FLOOR — NIGHT

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 8:06 PM EST

The CEO's office: white, gold, and modern, with orchids and a Romare Bearden collage. Across Peachtree, through the glass, the SMILLEY sign glows platinum.

NATASHA DONOHUE BULLOCK (43) works at her desk in reading glasses, surrounded by quarterly reports. She's on the phone.

NATASHA

(into phone)

—then tell the Monaco zoning board that Donohue Hotels & Resorts would be happy to build them a new public library. With a very large reading room. Named after the chairman's mother.

(listening)

Yes, I know he hates his mother. That's why he'll say yes.

She hangs up. A knock.

Martin enters, perfectly composed, carrying a thick leather portfolio.

MARTIN

Aunt Natasha. You're here late.

NATASHA

(eyeing the portfolio)

Please tell me that's not more slides.

MARTIN

(setting it on her desk)

The Auburn Avenue deeds. All thirty-one. Original titles, chain of ownership, current tax status, and zoning.

Natasha looks at him over her reading glasses.

NATASHA

I said Friday.

MARTIN

I know.

NATASHA

It's Tuesday.

MARTIN

I know.

She opens the portfolio and flips through it. It's meticulous: tabbed, color-coded, flawless. She's impressed and doesn't hide it.

NATASHA

Martin, this is excellent work.

MARTIN

Thank you.

NATASHA

Truly. Granddaddy will be pleased.

MARTIN

(a beat too long)
Will he?

Natasha hears it. She takes off her glasses.

NATASHA

Sit down, baby.

He sits. She comes around the desk and sits in the chair beside him, not across.

NATASHA (CONT'D)

I know what yesterday felt like.
The doughnuts. The laughing. You
worked for weeks on that
presentation and your cousin
walked in with a box of sugar and
got a standing ovation.

MARTIN

It wasn't a standing ovation.

NATASHA

It felt like one.
(beat)
It felt like that to me too,
once. With Jasmine. She was the
oldest. The first. The one who
went to Washington. And I was the

second daughter who "liked
hotels."

MARTIN
(genuinely surprised)
You?

NATASHA
Me. Now look where the second
daughter is sitting.
(she taps the desk)
You don't have to be the loudest
one in the room, Martin. You just
have to be the one who's still
there when everybody else goes
home.

A long moment. It's the kindest anyone in the family has
been to him in a long time. Something almost human
flickers across his face.

Then it's gone.

MARTIN
Thank you, Aunt Natasha.
(beat, carefully)
May I say something? As family?

NATASHA
Of course.

MARTIN
The coin in the park. The
Blackwater coin.
(beat)
People are talking. Downtown. At
the club. They're saying things
about Uncle Robert.

Natasha's face doesn't change, but the temperature in the
room drops ten degrees.

NATASHA
What things?

MARTIN
That Bullock and Associates
represents a lot of cash clients.
That some of those clients might
be connected. I'm sure it's
nothing. I only mention it
because I'd hate for the family
to be surprised.

(standing)
I'm just trying to protect the
family.

Natasha rises too. She's four inches shorter than her
nephew and somehow looks down at him.

NATASHA
Martin.

MARTIN
Yes?

NATASHA
(pleasantly, with steel
underneath)
Protect your own house, baby.
I've got mine.

MARTIN
(a gracious nod)
Of course.

He leaves. Natasha stands alone at the glass. The Smiley
sign glows. She picks up her phone and dials.

NATASHA
(into phone)
Robert. Where are you?
(listening)
Good. Stay there. I'm coming
home.

She hangs up, grabs her coat, and looks at the deeds on
her desk: thirty-one of them, perfect.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
(to herself)
"Excellent work."

CUT TO:

20 INT. BELLE RIVE — KITCHEN — NIGHT
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 9:03 PM EST

The kitchen is warm and loud. Birthday-eve chaos. Every
surface is covered: a three-tier pound cake cooling on a
rack, bowls of frosting, and a crate of champagne.

NANA RUBY (66) presides over the pound cake with a spatula
and a scowl. GRACE BULLOCK (20) stands on a kitchen chair,
singing into a wooden spoon. MALLORY OLSON (19) sits at

the island with a laptop, playing a backing track through tinny speakers and filming Grace on a tiny digital camera.

GRACE

(singing)

"Crown me, crown me, put the gold
on my head—"

NANA RUBY

Get down off my good chair.

Marc comes in the back door, still in his camel coat,
bringing the cold in with him.

MARC

Whose birthday is it?

GRACE, MALLORY, AND NANA RUBY

(in unison)

Not yet!

MARC

It's three hours away. That's
basically now.

He goes straight for the pound cake. Nana Ruby smacks his
hand with the spatula without looking.

NANA RUBY

That's tomorrow's.

MARC

I just want a corner.

NANA RUBY

There ain't no corners on a round
cake.

MARC

Then I'll make one.

NANA RUBY

(pointing the spatula
at him)

Marc-Anthony Bullock, I have been
making you this cake every
January fifth since you were
born. Your mama was in labor at
Crawford Long and I was in this
kitchen beating eggs. You will
eat it TOMORROW, like a

Christian.

Marc hugs her from behind and rests his chin on her shoulder. She pretends to be annoyed. She's not.

Grace hops down from the chair and wraps her arms around his waist from the other side. Now he's sandwiched between Grace and Nana Ruby.

GRACE

Tomorrow I'm singing you a new song. I wrote it for you.

MARC

Is it about me?

GRACE

It's about a man who's too handsome and too loud and eats cake before his birthday.

MARC

That sounds like a very realistic song.

MALLORY

(filming)

For the Grace and Glory website. We pitch Great-Grandma Simone on Thursday.

MARC

(wincing)

Good luck. She once made a Senator cry over a tax bill.

The back door opens again. Robert comes in, in a fresh pressed shirt, no tie, looking relaxed.

ROBERT

There's my birthday boy.

NANA RUBY

(not turning from the cake)

You changed your shirt.

A tiny beat.

ROBERT

Spilled coffee.

NANA RUBY
At seven o'clock at night.

ROBERT
Decaf.

Nana Ruby turns her head and looks at him for exactly two seconds. Then she goes back to her frosting.

Grace sees the look. So does Marc. Neither says anything.

The front door opens. Natasha sweeps in, coat still on.

NATASHA
Everybody out of my kitchen
except my husband.

GRACE
It's Nana Ruby's kitchen.

NATASHA
Everybody out of Nana Ruby's
kitchen except my husband.

MARC
(grabbing a spoon of
frosting on his way
out)
Night, Mama.

NATASHA
(catching his face,
kissing his cheek)
Three hours, baby. Twenty-three.

MARC
Don't remind me.

He leaves with Grace and Mallory, who are still arguing about flat notes. Nana Ruby takes her apron off slowly, gives Robert one more look, and exits.

Robert and Natasha are alone.

ROBERT
What's wrong?

NATASHA
Martin came to my office tonight.

ROBERT
To do what?

NATASHA
To bring me the Auburn deeds
three days early. And to tell me,
very kindly, that people downtown
are saying Bullock and Associates
represents Blackwater.

Robert pours himself a glass of water. His back is to her.

ROBERT
People downtown say a lot of
things.

NATASHA
Martin doesn't.
(beat)
Robert. Look at me.

He turns.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
Do you?

ROBERT
(evenly)
Do I what?

NATASHA
Represent them.

A long beat. It's the same question Camille asked two
hours ago. He gives the same answer.

ROBERT
I represent a lot of people who
pay in cash, baby. I don't ask
what they do at night.

NATASHA
(stepping close, very
quietly)
Then start asking. Because if our
nephew is whispering your name at
my desk, somebody is whispering
it to him.

She holds his eyes. Then she turns and walks out.

Robert stands alone in the kitchen with the three-tier
birthday cake.

CUT TO:

21 INT. CITY HALL EAST – APD CRIME LAB – NIGHT
Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 9:46 PM EST

A cramped forensics lab with fluorescent lights.
Microscopes and evidence bags.

Jeremy stands over a stainless-steel table beside an APD
LAB TECH in a lab coat. Elxa enters, sipping cold coffee.

On the table, side by side on black velvet under a
magnifying lamp, are TWO ONYX COINS. Each bears a crown
above a wave.

JEREMY

Last night's, from the park. And
this one's from the Harlow
evidence locker, October 2000.
Found on the kitchen table in
Vaughn Harlow's apartment.

ELXA

They look the same.

LAB TECH

They're both genuine onyx. Same
diameter to the tenth of a
millimeter. Same weight within a
gram.

ELXA

So it's them.

JEREMY

(leaning over the lamp)
Look at the wave.

Elxa leans in beside him. The coins are magnified under
the lamp.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

The Harlow coin: count the crests
on the wave.

ELXA

(counting)
One, two, three, four, five, six,
seven.

JEREMY

Now the park coin.

ELXA

(counting)

One, two, three, four, five...
(beat)
Six.

She straightens up. She looks at Jeremy.

ELXA (CONT'D)
Six.

JEREMY
Six.

LAB TECH
It's the kind of thing you'd only
notice if you were looking for
it. The engraving's very good.
Laser-cut. Recent work. The
Harlow coin was cut by hand.

ELXA
(slowly)
So either Blackwater got a new
jeweler...

JEREMY
...or somebody made a copy.

Silence. Elxa stares at the two coins.

ELXA
(quietly, to herself)
"Coins can be copied."

JEREMY
You said that this morning, too.

ELXA
(snapping back)
Nobody hears about the six
crests. Not the press. Not the
FBI. Not Hughes. Nobody.

LAB TECH
Yes, ma'am.

JEREMY
Not even your family?

Elxa looks at him. It's the question she's been avoiding
all day.

ELXA
(beat)

Especially not my family.

FADE OUT.

ACT SIX

22 INT. THE DOWAGER HOUSE — SIMONE'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 — 10:22 PM EST

A Creole bedroom with a four-poster bed hung in ivory mosquito netting she's kept since New Orleans. Candles. A photograph of Alexander on the nightstand, young and grinning, in 1933.

SIMONE DONOHUE (94) sits at her vanity in a silk bed jacket, brushing her long silver hair with a tortoiseshell brush. One hundred strokes. She has done it every night of her life.

A knock. WINSTON FAIRLEY (62) enters carrying a flat, worn leather JEWELRY CASE, holding it the way a priest carries a relic.

WINSTON

From the vault, madam. As you asked.

SIMONE

Thank you, Winston. Set it here.

He places it on the vanity. She sets down her brush and opens the case.

Nested in faded blue velvet lies a single long strand of enormous BLACK TAHITIAN PEARLS, dark as the river at night, each one catching the candlelight with a green-violet sheen.

Winston has worked in this family thirty-seven years. Even he inhales.

WINSTON

The other pearls.

SIMONE

(touching them lightly)
Alexander bought them in Papeete in 1952. On the way home from Savannah. He said, "Simone, from now on, when we go to war, you wear these, and everybody will know."

(beat)

I've worn them three times.

WINSTON

Yes, madam. The night of the cross. The Nixon dinner. And—

SIMONE

And Alexander's funeral.
(she closes the case
gently)
The Smilley girl will come tomorrow.

WINSTON

Madam, Mr. Lucius has made it quite clear no Smilley will—

SIMONE

Mr. Lucius isn't the Smilley who matters anymore, Winston. He lit his tower at sunrise and sent his daughter to cut the ribbon. The girl makes the decisions now.
(beat)
And a girl who idles at my gate for fifty-eight seconds is a girl who's going to come back.

WINSTON

(despite himself)
Fifty-eight seconds, madam? How do you know it was fifty-eight?

SIMONE

(picking her brush back up)
Winston, I've lived on this bluff for forty-seven years. I know when a squirrel crosses the lawn.

She resumes brushing. Stroke. Stroke.

SIMONE (CONT'D)

Leave the case. Just in case.

WINSTON

(bowing)
Just in case, madam.

He withdraws. Simone looks at the closed jewelry case in the mirror, and then at the photograph of her husband.

SIMONE

(to the photo, softly)
I invited her, Alexander.

(beat)
Don't look at me like that. You'd
have done the same.

CUT TO:

23 EXT. BELMONT CREST – THE RIVER GATE – NIGHT

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 10:58 PM EST

The black Chattahoochee. No moon again. The single iron lantern burns over the boathouse door.

Figures come down the bluff path one by one out of the darkness, a few minutes apart, from different directions.

Mama Dee, in a church coat, carrying a covered pie dish. Saint, hands in his leather jacket. Roman, silent. Tobias, with a laptop bag. A slim woman in black with her hood up: Keisha.

They each knock twice on the boathouse door and disappear inside.

INT. THE RIVER GATE BOATHOUSE – THE TABLE – CONTINUOUS

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 11:01 PM EST

The inside of the old stone boathouse has been transformed. The boats are gone. The walls are bare stone and the floor is old wood, with the river audible beneath it.

In the center stands a long, heavy, black-lacquered TABLE, with a single chandelier of iron and candles above it. EIGHT high-backed chairs surround it, each carved with the crown and wave.

Seven of them are filled.

At the head sits MARC. SOVEREIGN. He wears a black sweater, and the laughing birthday boy from the kitchen is nowhere in his face.

At his right hand: AMOND BAKER.

Around the table:

TOBIAS OKAFOR (24), "The Ledger," with his laptop open.

KEISHA "GHOST" LATTIMORE (25), "The Ghost." She has shaved sides and black nail polish, and she doesn't blink. A printout sits in front of her.

ROMAN GAINES (28), "The Hammer," arms folded, awake for thirty hours and showing none of it.

DOLORES "MAMA DEE" WHITFIELD (53), "The Tithe." She's already uncovering a sweet-potato pie and cutting it into slices.

RASHAD "SAINT" MAYFIELD (23), "The Saint," tipping his chair back on two legs.

And at the far end of the table, facing Marc, is the EIGHTH CHAIR. Empty. Its seat is covered in black velvet. Nobody looks at it directly. Everybody knows it's there.

MAMA DEE
(sliding plates around
the table)
Eat first. Then we'll talk about
who needs to disappear.

SAINT
(already eating)
Mama Dee, this is the best pie in
Georgia.

MAMA DEE
It's the best pie in the South,
baby. Georgia's too small a word.

A small ripple of laughter. Marc lets it pass, then speaks. The room goes still.

MARC
Thank you all for coming.
(beat)
Roman. You just flew halfway
around the world.

ROMAN
(shrugging)
It was on the way home.

Marc nods to Keisha.

MARC
Ghost.

Keisha slides her printout to the center of the table. It shows two photographs side by side, magnified: the coin from the park and one of their own coins.

KEISHA

I got into APD's evidence system at six this morning. They just logged a lab comparison, as of nine-fifty tonight.

(tapping the photos)

Our coins have seven crests on the wave. Always have. Mama Dee's original thousand, and every one since.

(beat)

The park coin has six.

The table goes silent.

TOBIAS

A counterfeit.

KEISHA

A good one. Real onyx. Laser-cut. Expensive. Somebody spent money making this.

SAINT

So somebody made fake Blackwater coins, killed one of Silas's men with one, and waited for everybody to blame us.

KEISHA

That's what the evidence says.

AMOND

And the police know about the six crests?

KEISHA

The Chief and her husband do. She ordered it kept quiet. Not the press, not the FBI.

(glancing at Marc)

"Especially not my family."

Something flickers across Marc's face. It's gone.

MARC

Tobias.

TOBIAS

Lamar Whitlock received twenty thousand dollars in cash at his credit union on December tenth. He was paid for something. Three weeks later he was dead in a park.

ROMAN

Paid to set somebody up.

TOBIAS

Or paid to be set up. We don't know yet.

MARC

Saint. The streets.

SAINT

(chair legs down,
serious)

Merriweather's people are saying we broke the truce. Two of my car washes got threatened tonight. Everybody on the Southside is waiting to see what Silas does.

MARC

Mama Dee.

Mama Dee sets down her pie server. She takes a long breath.

MAMA DEE

Silas sent me a funeral wreath today, baby. Black lilies. Four hundred dollars of them. In the middle of my restaurant, at dinnertime, in front of the children.

(beat)

The ribbon said "Sweet Auburn Truce, Rest in Peace."

A dangerous silence. Roman's arms slowly unfold.

ROMAN

He threatened you.

MAMA DEE

He sent me flowers, Roman.

ROMAN

In your restaurant.

MAMA DEE

(calmly)

Silas Merriweather and I have known each other since we were both twelve years old and fighting over the last seat at the Royal Peacock. If he wanted to threaten me, he'd have sent a man, not a florist.

(beat)

That wreath wasn't a threat. It was a question.

MARC

What's the question?

MAMA DEE

"Did you do this?"

The table absorbs it.

ROMAN

(to Marc)

We can end this tonight. Silas has seven funeral homes and forty soldiers. I can have—

MARC

No.

It's quiet, and it's absolute.

MARC (CONT'D)

Silas didn't do this. And neither did we.

(beat)

Somebody killed a man who drove a hearse and brought his mama to church. Somebody put our name in his hand. And somebody wants Roman to do exactly what Roman just offered to do.

(beat)

If we go to war with Silas this week, whoever did this wins, and they never have to fire another shot.

Roman holds his gaze, then nods once.

AMOND

Then what do we do?

Marc stands. He walks slowly around the long table, past each chair, past each face.

MARC

Mama Dee. Tomorrow you take Silas a sweet-potato pie. You sit in his parlor, you tell him we didn't do it, and you tell him Sovereign swears it on the Code.

(beat)

And you tell him we'll prove it.

MAMA DEE

(nodding)

He'll want proof by Friday.

MARC

Then he'll have it by Friday.

(moving on)

Ghost. The six crests. Somebody laser-cut these. There aren't a hundred people on Earth who make onyx coins at that quality. Find the one who made these.

KEISHA

Already looking.

MARC

Tobias. The twenty thousand. Find who paid Lamar.

TOBIAS

Yes.

MARC

Saint. Keep the streets cold. Nobody touches a Merriweather man. Nobody touches a Merriweather building. If one of ours so much as honks at a hearse, I want to know.

SAINT

Cold as a Chicago February.

MARC

(to Roman)

Roman. Find the shooter.

ROMAN
(standing)
Yes.

MARC
And Roman.

ROMAN
Yes.

MARC
Alive.

Roman looks at him and nods. It's clearly not his favorite instruction.

Marc stops at the far end of the table, beside the EIGHTH CHAIR. He rests his hand on its carved back.

He looks down the length of the table at the six people who would die for him.

MARC (CONT'D)
Somebody's using our coin.
(beat)
Someone out there has studied us.
They know our mark. They know the
truce. They know what Silas would
think. They know exactly where to
put a body so my sister has to
stand over it on television.
(quiet)
That's not a stranger. That's
somebody close.

A long silence. The river rushes beneath the floorboards.

SAINT
(gently, nodding at the
empty chair under
Marc's hand)
Still saving that seat, boss?

Marc looks down at his hand on the chair, as if he'd forgotten it was there.

MARC
(beat)
Still saving it.

He lets go of the chair.

MARC (CONT'D)

That's all. Go home. Sleep.

(beat)

And somebody eat the rest of that pie, or Mama Dee's going to take it personally.

MAMA DEE

I already take it personally.

The tension breaks and they rise. Chairs scrape. Saint takes two slices of pie. Keisha is already gone, the door swinging behind her. Tobias shakes Marc's hand. Roman simply nods.

Mama Dee stops beside Marc, reaches up, and straightens his collar, the way she does.

MAMA DEE (CONT'D)

(softly, just for him)

Happy birthday in forty minutes, baby.

MARC

Thank you, Mama Dee.

MAMA DEE

Don't you let this take the joy out of your birthday. You hear me? They'd love that too.

She leaves. Only Amond remains.

INT. THE RIVER GATE BOATHOUSE – LATER

Tuesday, January 4, 2005 – 11:52 PM EST

Candles burn low. Marc and Amond sit at the empty table, side by side, drinking bourbon from the bottle Saint left.

MARC

How was the parking deck?

AMOND

(beat)

She shoved a car seat at me. With the baby in it.

MARC

(wincing)

Oof.

AMOND

And then she said I never once asked how she was doing. In three years.

MARC

Have you?

AMOND

(beat)

No.

MARC

So did you ask?

AMOND

I asked. In a parking deck. She told me not to dare.

MARC

(nodding sagely)

That's progress.

AMOND

How is that progress?

MARC

She answered you. Three years ago she wouldn't have.

Amond almost laughs. He drinks.

AMOND

My mother wants one Sunday a month. She'll withdraw the petition if Harmony says yes.

(beat)

Lyric likes greens. Did you know that? My mother knew. I didn't.

Marc looks at him with total understanding.

MARC

Now you know.

A beat. The chandelier's candles gutter. Out on the river, somewhere, a church bell in a distant town begins to toll midnight.

Amond checks his watch. He grins.

AMOND

Hey.

MARC

What.

AMOND

(raising the bottle)
Happy birthday, Sovereign.

MARC

(clinking with his
glass)
Thank you, Right Hand.

In Marc's pocket, his RAZR BUZZES. He pulls it out and looks at the screen. He smiles, a real, boyish, delighted smile, the first since dusk.

INSERT — CALLER ID: "GORGEOUS"

MARC (CONT'D)

(answering)
You're supposed to be asleep.

INTERCUT WITH:

INT. THE DOWAGER HOUSE — SIMONE'S BEDROOM — CONTINUOUS

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 12:00 AM EST

Simone sits in her four-poster, propped against lace pillows, holding an old rotary phone receiver. The candles are out. The jewelry case sits on the vanity.

SIMONE

I've called you at midnight on
your birthday every year since
you were born, Sunshine. I'm not
stopping for sleep.

MARC

(to Amond, covering the
phone)
It's Gorgeous.

AMOND

(grinning)
Tell her I said hi.

MARC

(into phone)
Amond says hi.

SIMONE

Tell Amond to go home to his
mother. She's lonely.

MARC

(to Amond)

She says go home to your mother.

AMOND

(standing, laughing)

How does she KNOW that?

He pats Marc's shoulder and heads out into the night.

SIMONE

Twenty-three.

MARC

Twenty-three.

SIMONE

Your great-grandfather was
twenty-three when he bought his
first hotel. The Donohue House.
Twelve rooms. Leaky roof. Every
bed full.

MARC

I know, Gorgeous. You've told me
every year.

SIMONE

And I'll tell you next year too.
A thing worth saying is worth
saying twice.

(beat)

Where are you?

MARC

(looking around the
candlelit boathouse)

Down by the river.

A pause on the line. Simone looks toward her dark window,
toward the bluff, toward the river she can't see from
here.

SIMONE

(softly)

The river gets in the soul,
Sunshine.

MARC

I know.

SIMONE

Go to bed. Tomorrow you'll have three hundred people and an ice sculpture that looks like a duck.

MARC

How do you know about the duck?

SIMONE

(pleased with herself)
Good night, Marc-Anthony. Happy birthday.

MARC

(beat)
Good night, Gorgeous. I love you.

SIMONE

I know, baby. Everybody does.
That's your trouble.

END INTERCUT.

She hangs up. Marc sits alone at the black table in the dim light, twenty-three years old, looking at the empty eighth chair.

CUT TO:

24 INT. MARTIN OLSON'S LOFT — MIDTOWN — NIGHT

Wednesday, January 5, 2005 — 12:03 AM EST

The loft is dark except for a single desk lamp.

Martin sits at a steel desk. In front of him is a fresh yellow legal pad. In neat, small, perfect capitals, he has written a heading:

INSERT — THE LEGAL PAD: "SOVEREIGN — WHO?"

Beneath it is a list, several lines long. Some names are crossed out. Some have question marks. One line near the bottom reads:

INSERT — "ROBERT BULLOCK (?) — cash clients / Merriweather inquiry / Harlow 2000 — defense attorney for 3 of the ring"

Martin taps his pen against the name, once, twice.

Then, slowly, he draws a neat circle around it.

On the desk beside the legal pad sits a cream-colored envelope with a gold crown. It's his invitation to tomorrow night's party at Belle Rive.

He glances at it. He smiles.

He switches off the lamp.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE #0002

NEXT ON BEYOND THE KINGDOM...

— At Belle Rive, three hundred guests raise their glasses. GRACE, at the microphone: "This one's called 'Crown Me.' It's for my big brother."

— SIMONE presses an antique gold POCKET WATCH into MARC's palm: "This was his. He'd want it ticking."

— CELESTE, in red, turns to see a woman arriving at the Crown Gate in a car. She's also in red.

— At the guardhouse, ESTHER leans forward to look at the security monitor. On the screen, MARC is laughing. She sits back. ESTHER: "Turn the car around."

FADE TO BLACK.